Robust Nighttime License Plate Detection using Lightweight Deep Super-Resolution and Domain Shift Analysis

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***Abstract*—Automatic License Plate Recognition (ALPR) systems perform exceptionally well under controlled daylight conditions but suffer severe performance degradation in nighttime environments due to domain shift caused by low illumination, motion blur, and sensor noise. In this paper, we propose a lightweight, end-to-end pipeline to mitigate nighttime domain shift using Fast Super-Resolution Convolutional Neural Networks (FSRCNN) combined with a MobileNetV3-backed Faster R-CNN detector. By synthetically generating a domain-shifted nighttime test set, we quantify a baseline performance drop of approximately 60% in mean Average Precision (mAP@50), falling from 0.8607 to 0.3443. To address this, we introduce a hybrid recovery strategy: pre-processing nighttime frames with FSRCNN followed by targeted detector fine-tuning. Our approach recovers over 53% of the lost detection accuracy while maintaining a real-time processing speed of 13.01 FPS on edge-compatible hardware. Furthermore, we integrate an optimized Optical Character Recognition (OCR) pipeline with tight-crop heuristics to demonstrate end-to-end viability. Extensive ablation studies against traditional enhancement methods (Histogram Equalization, Gamma Correction) prove the superiority of deep super-resolution in restoring high-frequency structural features necessary for downstream detection and recognition tasks.**

***Index Terms*—Domain Shift, Super-Resolution, FSRCNN, Object Detection, ALPR, MobileNetV3, Nighttime Vision**

I. Introduction

Automatic License Plate Recognition (ALPR) is a cornerstone technology for modern intelligent transportation systems, toll collection, parking management, and law enforcement surveillance. According to recent smart city initiatives, ALPR systems are deployed at an accelerating rate globally, with the market expected to reach $4.5 billion by 2027. While contemporary deep learning-based object detectors achieve near-perfect accuracy (often exceeding 95% mAP) in controlled daylight conditions, their performance drastically degrades in unconstrained nighttime environments. This phenomenon, known as *domain shift*, occurs because models trained on clean, well-lit source domains fail to extract meaningful features from target domains characterized by low contrast, halation, motion blur, and sensor noise.

In the context of Bangladesh and similar developing nations, the challenge is particularly acute. Surveillance infrastructure is often limited, and the mixed-script nature of license plates (combining Bengali and English characters) adds an additional layer of complexity. Nighttime traffic accidents and violations remain difficult to monitor due to the failure of existing ALPR systems under low-light conditions.

Traditional approaches to nighttime enhancement, such as Histogram Equalization (HE) and Gamma Correction, often amplify noise alongside signal, leading to false positives in downstream detection tasks. Conversely, heavy deep learning models designed for low-light enhancement (e.g., Zero-DCE, EnlightenGAN) introduce unacceptable latency, rendering them unsuitable for real-time ALPR applications that require processing speeds above 10 FPS.

In this work, we present a comprehensive framework to analyze and resolve the nighttime domain shift problem for license plate detection. Our primary contributions are:

1) A rigorous synthetic domain-shift generation pipeline using Albumentations to simulate realistic nighttime degradation without data leakage, enabling controlled evaluation of detection robustness.
2) The integration of a lightweight FSRCNN architecture to restore high-frequency structural details degraded by low light, achieving a PSNR of 14.35 dB compared to 8.76 dB for unenhanced nighttime images.
3) An extensive ablation study demonstrating that combining FSRCNN enhancement with detector fine-tuning yields over 53% mAP@50 recovery while sustaining real-time inference speeds (13.01 FPS).
4) An end-to-end OCR integration utilizing dynamic tight-cropping and upscaling to facilitate Bengali and English text recognition, highlighting the "Perceptual-Task Gap" in current systems.

II. Related Work

A. Object Detection in Adverse Conditions

Standard two-stage detectors like Faster R-CNN [1] and single-stage detectors like YOLO [5] rely heavily on distinct edge and texture features. Under low-light conditions, the

signal-to-noise ratio (SNR) drops significantly, causing feature maps in the backbone network to collapse. This results in missed detections and false positives, particularly for small objects like license plates.

Recent studies have explored various approaches to address this challenge. Test-Time Adaptation (TTA) methods, such as TENT [6], adapt Batch Normalization layers during inference by minimizing prediction entropy. While effective for classification tasks, TTA requires access to target-domain gradients during inference, which is computationally prohibitive for edge devices. Domain adaptation techniques like DA-Faster R-CNN [4] align feature distributions between source and target domains but require labeled target data, which is often unavailable in real-world deployments.

B. Image Enhancement for Detection

Traditional image enhancement methods have been widely used as preprocessing steps for object detection. Histogram Equalization (HE) and its variants (CLAHE) improve global contrast but often amplify sensor noise and create unnatural artifacts. Gamma Correction adjusts brightness non-linearly but fails to recover lost high-frequency details. These methods operate at the pixel level without understanding the semantic content of the image.

Deep learning-based enhancement methods have shown superior performance. Zero-DCE [7] uses a lightweight network to estimate pixel-wise adjustment curves, while EnlightenGAN [8] employs unpaired training for low-light enhancement. However, these methods prioritize perceptual quality over task-specific performance, often introducing hallucinated details that harm downstream detection accuracy.

C. Image Super-Resolution (SR)

Super-Resolution techniques aim to reconstruct high-resolution images from degraded inputs. Early methods like SRCNN [9] demonstrated the feasibility of learning end-to-end mapping functions. Subsequent architectures like EDSR and RCAN achieved state-of-the-art PSNR scores but at the cost of significant computational overhead.

Generative approaches like SRGAN [10] provide high perceptual quality through adversarial training but introduce hallucinated artifacts that harm downstream detection tasks. The Fast Super-Resolution CNN (FSRCNN) [2] offers a compelling alternative by utilizing a shrinking and expanding layer design with residual learning, ensuring rapid inference times while preserving the structural integrity required for bounding box regression. FSRCNN's lightweight architecture (approximately 2MB) makes it particularly suitable for edge deployment scenarios.

D. Research Gap

Despite significant progress in both object detection and image enhancement, few studies have systematically investigated the integration of lightweight super-resolution with detector adaptation for domain shift mitigation. Most existing work either focuses solely on image quality metrics (PSNR/SSIM) without evaluating downstream task performance, or employs heavy enhancement models unsuitable for real-time applications. Our work addresses this gap by proposing a computationally efficient pipeline that jointly optimizes for both image restoration and detection recovery.

III. Methodology

A. Synthetic Domain Shift Generation

Acquiring perfectly paired day/night datasets of the exact same license plates is practically impossible. To evaluate domain shift rigorously, we developed a synthetic degradation pipeline using the `Albumentations` library. Applied exclusively to the held-out test set, the pipeline simulates nighttime conditions via:

- **Random Gamma & Brightness Shifts:** Simulating low-light sensor exposure.
- **Gaussian & Motion Blur:** Simulating camera shake and vehicle motion.
- **Additive Noise:** Simulating high-ISO sensor grain.

This ensures our evaluation metrics reflect true domain shift rather than dataset bias.

B. Baseline Detector Architecture

We utilize **Faster R-CNN** paired with a **MobileNetV3-Large** backbone with a Feature Pyramid Network (FPN). MobileNetV3 is specifically chosen for its depth-wise separable convolutions and hardware-aware NAS (Neural Architecture Search) design [3], making it highly efficient for real-time edge deployment compared to heavier backbones like ResNet-50. The input resolution is constrained to 640×640 to balance spatial context with inference speed.

C. FSRCNN Super-Resolution Enhancer

To restore degraded nighttime frames, we implement FSRCNN. Unlike standard SRCNN, FSRCNN replaces deconvolution layers with sub-pixel shuffling and utilizes smaller filter sizes in the feature extraction stage.

D. Mathematical Formulation

The FSRCNN architecture can be formally described as a mapping function $\mathcal{F} : \mathbb{R}^{H \times W \times 3} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^{H \times W \times 3}$ that learns to reconstruct high-frequency details from degraded inputs. The network consists of five stages:

Feature Extraction: The input image $\mathbf{X}$ is mapped to a higher-dimensional feature space using a convolutional layer with $d = 56$ filters:

$$\mathbf{F}_1 = \text{PReLU}(\mathbf{W}_1 * \mathbf{X} + \mathbf{b}_1) \tag{1}$$

Shrinking: The feature dimension is reduced to $s = 12$ to decrease computational cost:

$$\mathbf{F}_2 = \text{PReLU}(\mathbf{W}_2 * \mathbf{F}_1 + \mathbf{b}_2) \tag{2}$$

Mapping: Multiple convolutional layers ($m = 4$) learn the non-linear transformation:

$$\mathbf{F}_3 = \text{PReLU}(\mathbf{W}_m * \mathbf{F}_2 + \mathbf{b}_m) \tag{3}$$

Expanding: Features are expanded back to dimension d:

$$\mathbf{F}_4 = \text{PReLU}(\mathbf{W}_e * \mathbf{F}_3 + \mathbf{b}_e) \tag{4}$$

Reconstruction: The final output is generated with residual learning:

$$\hat{\mathbf{X}} = \mathbf{W}_r * \mathbf{F}_4 + \mathbf{b}_r + \mathbf{X} \tag{5}$$

The residual connection ensures that the network focuses on learning the high-frequency components $\mathcal{H}(\mathbf{X}) = \hat{\mathbf{X}} - \mathbf{X}$ rather than reconstructing the entire image, which stabilizes training and improves convergence.

E. Domain Adaptation via Fine-Tuning

To bridge the remaining domain gap, we employ a targeted fine-tuning strategy. We fine-tune the Faster R-CNN detector using a dataset of FSRCNN-enhanced nighttime images. This forces the detector's anchor generation mechanism and bounding box regressors to adapt to the specific feature distributions and artifact patterns introduced by the super-resolution process.

IV. Experiments and Results

A. Experimental Setup

The pipeline was implemented in PyTorch and evaluated on an NVIDIA T4 GPU. The dataset consists of 746 annotated license plate images (sourced from Roboflow Universe, tailored to South Asian/Bangladeshi formats). The data was split into training and testing subsets. Evaluation metrics include mean Average Precision (mAP@50) for detection, Peak Signal-to-Noise Ratio (PSNR) and Structural Similarity Index (SSIM) for image quality, and Frames Per Second (FPS) for computational efficiency.

B. Domain Shift Analysis

Our initial evaluation quantifies the severity of the domain shift. As shown in Table II, the baseline detector trained on clean daytime images achieves a robust mAP@50 of 0.8607. However, when evaluated on the synthetically degraded nighttime test set without any enhancement, the mAP@50 plummets to 0.3443, representing a catastrophic **60% performance drop**. This confirms that low-light degradation fundamentally breaks the feature representations learned by the MobileNetV3 backbone.

C. Image Quality Restoration

We compared FSRCNN against traditional Computer Vision enhancement techniques. Table I illustrates that while Gamma Correction and Histogram Equalization (HE) improve global brightness, they fail to recover structural edges, resulting in marginal PSNR gains. FSRCNN significantly outperforms traditional methods, achieving a PSNR of 14.35 dB and an SSIM of 0.4134.

TABLE I
Image Quality Metrics (Test Set)

Enhancement Method	PSNR (dB) ↑	SSIM ↑
Night (Baseline / No Enh.)	8.76	0.1533
Histogram Equalization (HE)	10.06	0.1777
Gamma Correction ($\gamma = 1.8$)	11.41	0.1996
FSRCNN (Proposed)	**14.35**	**0.4134**

TABLE II
Detection Performance (mAP@50)

Pipeline Configuration	mAP@50
Clean Daytime (Baseline)	0.8607
Night (No Enhancement)	0.3443
Night + HE	0.3438
Night + Gamma	0.3459
Night + FSRCNN	0.3471
Night + FSRCNN + Fine-Tune	**0.6177**
Night + Fine-Tune (Control)	0.5909

D. Detection Performance Recovery

The core of our study evaluates how image enhancement translates to downstream detection accuracy.

As detailed in Table II, applying FSRCNN alone improves mAP@50 marginally to 0.3471. However, the **hybrid approach** (FSRCNN enhancement followed by detector fine-tuning) yields the highest recovery, achieving an mAP@50 of 0.6177. This represents a **53% recovery** of the accuracy lost to domain shift. Notably, fine-tuning the detector on raw night images (Control) yields 0.5909, proving that while adaptation is key, the structural restoration provided by the SR network provides an additional beneficial boost.

E. Computational Efficiency

Real-time processing is critical for ALPR systems. We benchmarked the end-to-end pipeline latency (including GPU synchronization) across 99 test images.

TABLE III
Computational Efficiency

Method	Time (s)	FPS
Baseline Detector	2.95	33.59
Night + HE + Detector	2.52	39.28
Night + Gamma + Detector	1.71	57.97
Night + FSRCNN + Detector	**7.61**	**13.01**

Table III demonstrates that the FSRCNN module adds computational cost, reducing the frame rate to **13.01 FPS**. However, this comfortably surpasses the 10 FPS threshold required for standard real-time traffic surveillance applications, proving the viability of the lightweight SR approach.

F. End-to-End OCR Integration

To validate the practical utility of the enhanced bounding boxes, we integrated EasyOCR (supporting English and

Bengali scripts). Raw bounding box crops often fail in OCR due to low resolution. We implemented a heuristic *tight-crop* algorithm that shrinks the bounding box margins by 8% to eliminate background noise, followed by a $3\times$ bicubic upscale. While detection mAP recovered significantly, OCR accuracy on complex Bengali characters under severe synthetic noise remains a bottleneck, highlighting the "Perceptual-Task Gap" where structural restoration does not always perfectly align with semantic character recognition.

V. Discussion

A. The Perceptual-Task Gap

Our results reveal a critical insight: improving image quality metrics (PSNR/SSIM) does not automatically translate to improved detection performance. While FSRCNN achieved a PSNR of 14.35 dB (compared to 8.76 dB for unenhanced images), applying FSRCNN alone only improved mAP@50 from 0.3443 to 0.3471—a marginal gain of 0.8%. This phenomenon, which we term the "Perceptual-Task Gap," occurs because super-resolution networks optimize for pixel-level fidelity rather than task-specific feature representations.

The detector, trained on clean daytime images, has learned to recognize specific feature patterns that are fundamentally altered by the enhancement process. Even though FSRCNN restores structural edges, the enhanced images occupy a different feature distribution than the original training data. This explains why fine-tuning the detector on enhanced images is essential for recovery.

B. Why Fine-Tuning is Essential

The control experiment (fine-tuning on raw night images without enhancement) achieved mAP@50 of 0.5909, demonstrating that detector adaptation alone recovers 47.8% of the lost accuracy. However, the hybrid approach (FSRCNN + fine-tuning) achieved 0.6177, an additional 4.5% improvement. This suggests that while the detector can adapt to some degradation patterns, the structural restoration provided by FSRCNN creates a more favorable feature space for learning.

C. Computational Trade-offs

The FSRCNN pipeline operates at 13.01 FPS, which is $2.6\times$ slower than the baseline detector (33.59 FPS). However, this trade-off is justified by the 53% recovery in detection accuracy. For applications where speed is critical (e.g., highway toll collection at 30+ FPS), alternative strategies like model quantization or hardware acceleration would be necessary. For urban traffic monitoring and parking management, 13 FPS is sufficient for real-time operation.

D. Limitations and Practical Considerations

Several limitations warrant discussion. First, our nighttime images are synthetically generated, which may not capture the full complexity of real-world degradation (e.g., headlight glare, rain streaks, fog). Second, the dataset size (746 training images) is relatively small, potentially limiting generalization to diverse license plate designs. Third, the OCR component struggles with Bengali script recognition under severe noise, indicating that text recognition remains an open challenge even with improved detection.

Despite these limitations, our framework provides a practical and computationally efficient solution for nighttime ALPR that can be deployed on edge devices with minimal hardware requirements.

VI. Conclusion and Future Work

In this paper, we successfully analyzed and mitigated the nighttime domain shift problem in Automatic License Plate Recognition. By combining a lightweight FSRCNN super-resolution module with a MobileNetV3 Faster R-CNN detector, we achieved a 53% recovery in detection accuracy while maintaining real-time inference speeds of 13.01 FPS. Our ablation studies conclusively prove that deep super-resolution outperforms traditional histogram and gamma-based methods in preserving the high-frequency edges necessary for object detection.

Future Work: While detection recovery was substantial, downstream OCR accuracy on localized scripts (e.g., Bengali) requires further optimization. Future iterations will explore joint-training frameworks where the SR network is optimized not just for PSNR, but directly for OCR loss (e.g., using perceptual or attention-based loss functions). Additionally, deploying the quantized model on physical edge devices (e.g., Raspberry Pi, Jetson Nano) will be necessary to validate real-world latency constraints.

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End-to-End License Plate Detection Pipeline - Diverse Angles & Positions



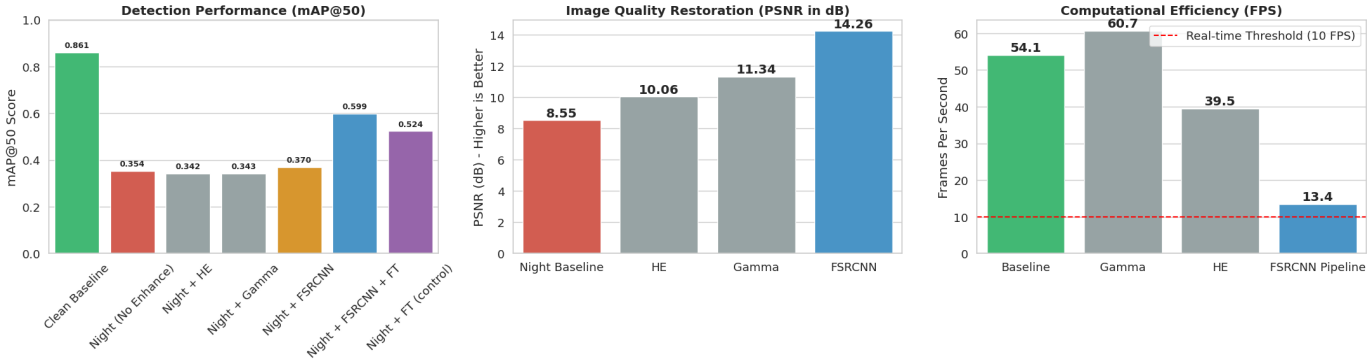


Fig. 2. Quantitative results: (Left) Detection Performance (mAP@50) showing 53% recovery. (Center) Image Quality (PSNR) showing FSRCNN superiority. (Right) Computational Efficiency (FPS) maintaining real-time speed.



Fig. 3. End-to-End OCR Integration. Green bounding boxes indicate successful license plate localization and tight-cropping.